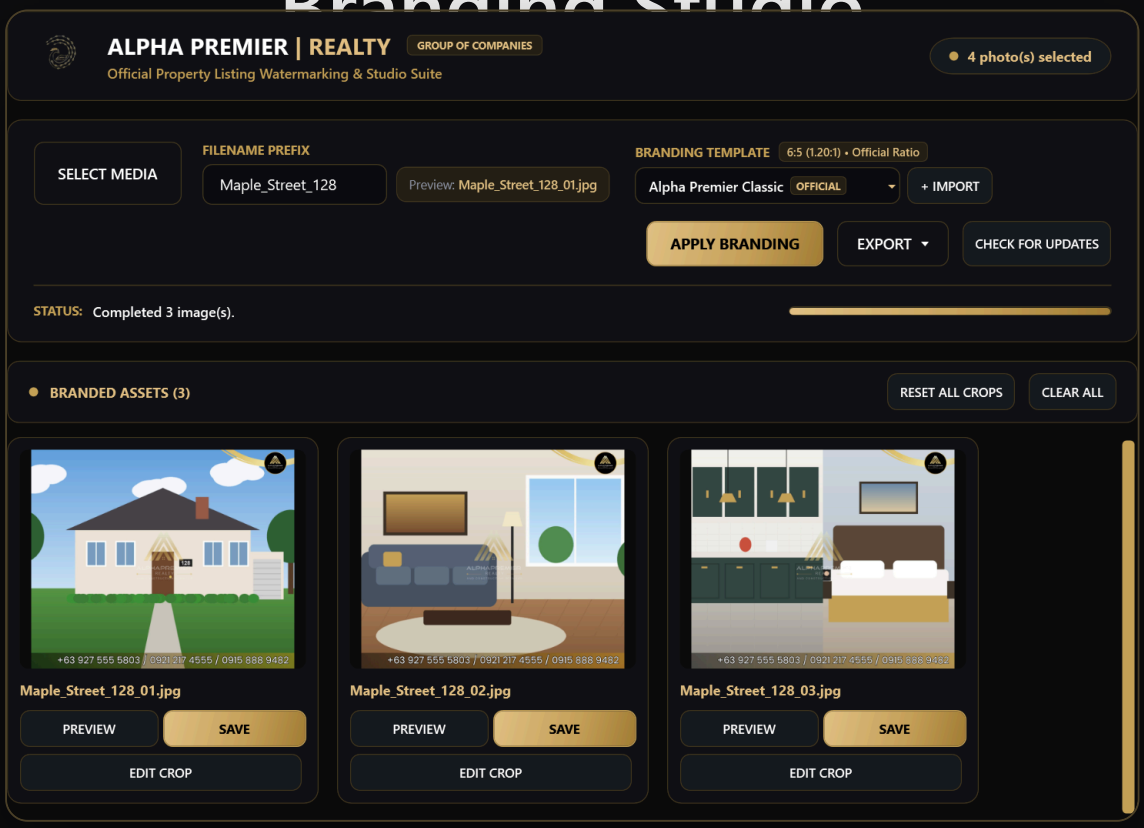
ALPHA PREMIER
GROUP OF COMPANIES

USER MANUAL

# Alpha Premier Property Branding Studio



BEFORE YOU BEGIN

# About this manual

This manual explains how to install and use **Alpha Premier Property Branding Studio** (called "Branding Studio" in this manual). It is written for listing agents, marketing staff, and photographers who prepare property media for Alpha Premier Realty listings. No technical background is needed.

The chapters follow the order of a normal working session. If you only want to brand a batch of photos quickly, read **Chapter 3, Quick start**, which takes about five minutes.

## Conventions used in this manual

| Convention | Meaning |
|---|---|
| **APPLY BRANDING** | A button, menu item, or label exactly as it appears on screen. |
| `Ctrl` + `O` | A keyboard shortcut. Hold the first key and press the second. |
| 1 | A numbered marker on a screenshot. The table under each figure explains what each number points to. |
| `%LOCALAPPDATA%` | A file path, file name, or text you type. |

> **NOTE**
> Gives extra information that helps you understand a feature.

> **TIP**
> Suggests a faster or better way to do something.

> **CAUTION**
> Warns you about something that can lose work or produce an unexpected result.

Screenshots in this manual use sample illustrations in place of real listing photos. Your screen will show your own media. Screenshots were taken at 100% display scaling; at higher scaling, some button rows wrap onto a second line.

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CHAPTER 1

# Introduction

Branding Studio applies the official Alpha Premier Realty frame (logo, gold accents, and contact numbers) to property photos and video clips. Every output has the same size and look, ready to post on listing sites and social media.

This manual shows the Windows app. A Mac app with the same features is also available; Chapter 2 explains how to install it and Chapter 13 how it updates.

## What you can do

- **Brand photos and videos in batches.** Add many files at once and process them with one click.
- **Combine portrait photos.** Two tall photos are placed side by side in one frame, so nothing is stretched or squashed.
- **Adjust framing before or after branding.** Pan, zoom, rotate, fit, or fill each photo behind the frame.
- **Hide private details.** Pixelate phone numbers on tarps and signs, house numbers, plates, family photos, or documents.
- **Name files consistently.** Output files are numbered automatically, for example `Maple_Street_128_01.jpg`.
- **Export in one step.** Save everything as one ZIP file or as separate files in a folder.
- **Use other templates.** Import extra frame images and switch between them.

## How a session works

| STEP 1 | STEP 2 | STEP 3 | STEP 4 | STEP 5 | STEP 6 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Select** | **Arrange** | **Crop** | **Apply** | **Review** | **Export** |
| Add photos and videos | Pair, separate, set the prefix | Frame each photo, hide details | Add the branding frame | Preview and fix | ZIP or files |

## Before and after

Branding Studio converts each photo to a 1200 × 1000 pixel image and adds the frame on top. You do not need to resize your photos first.




**Figure 1-1.** An original exterior photo (left) and the branded result (right).

> **NOTE: YOUR MEDIA STAYS ON YOUR COMPUTER**
>
> All processing happens on your PC. Branding Studio does not upload your photos or videos anywhere. The only internet connection it makes is to check for software updates (Chapter 13).

CHAPTER 2

# Installation

## System requirements

| Item | Requirement |
|---|---|
| Operating system | Windows 10 (version 1809 or later) or Windows 11, 64-bit |
| Administrator rights | Not required. The app installs for your Windows user account only. |
| Extra software | None. Everything the app needs is included in the installer. |
| Internet | Only needed to download the installer and to check for updates. |
| Display | Works at 100%, 125%, 150%, 175%, and 200% Windows display scaling. Smallest window size: 840 × 480. |

## Option A: Install with the setup program (recommended)

1. Download `Alpha.Branding.Setup.exe` from the official release page: `github.com/Deign86/Alpha_Branding/releases/latest`. Your IT team may also give you the file directly.
2. Double-click `Alpha.Branding.Setup.exe`.
3. Follow the on-screen steps. No administrator password is needed.
4. When setup finishes, open **Start** and select **Alpha Premier Property Branding Studio**.

The app is installed to `%LOCALAPPDATA%\Alpha Premier Realty\Branding Studio` and a Start menu shortcut is created.

## Option B: Run the portable version

1. Download the `Alpha.Branding-v2.8.1-win-x64.zip` file from the same release page.
2. Right-click the ZIP file and select **Extract All**.
3. Open the extracted folder and double-click `Alpha.Branding.exe`.

Use the portable version if you cannot install software on your PC, or to run the app from a USB drive.

## Option C: Install on a Mac

The Mac app needs macOS 13 Ventura or later and runs on Apple silicon and Intel Macs.

1. From the same release page, download `Alpha.Branding-v2.8.1-macos.pkg` (the version number in the name changes with each release).
2. Double-click the file in your **Downloads** folder and follow the installer. It puts **Alpha Branding Studio** in **Applications**.
3. The app is not signed with an Apple Developer ID yet, so macOS may block the first open. Open **System Settings › Privacy & Security** and select **Open Anyway**. On macOS 13 or 14 you can also right-click the app and select **Open**.

> **NOTE**
>
> Mac versions before 2.8.0 cannot update themselves. Install the latest version once with these steps; after that the app offers new versions on its own (see Chapter 13). To remove the Mac app, drag it from **Applications** to the **Trash**.

## Uninstalling

1. Open **Settings › Apps › Installed apps** (Windows 11) or **Settings › Apps & features** (Windows 10).
2. Find **Alpha Premier Property Branding Studio**, select ⋯ or the app name, then select **Uninstall**.

Uninstalling removes the app. Files you have already exported are not affected.

## For IT administrators

The repository includes `Install.ps1` for unattended deployment through tools such as Action1 RMM or Microsoft Intune. It supports `-DownloadUrl`, `-AllUsers`, `-CreateDesktopShortcut`, and `-Uninstall`. To turn off update checks on a PC, set the machine environment variable `ALPHA_BRANDING_DISABLE_AUTO_UPDATE` to `1`. See the project README for full details.

CHAPTER 3

# Quick start: brand your first batch

Follow these steps to brand a set of listing photos and save them as a ZIP file. It takes about five minutes.

1. Open Branding Studio from the **Start** menu.
2. Select **SELECT MEDIA** (or press `Ctrl` + `O`). Choose your photos and select **Open**. You can also drag files from File Explorer onto the window.
3. In **FILENAME PREFIX**, type a name for this listing, for example `Maple_Street_128`. The **Preview** box shows the first file name.
4. Check that **BRANDING TEMPLATE** shows **Alpha Premier Classic**.
5. Optional: select **EDIT CROP** on any photo to change its framing (Chapter 7).
6. Select **APPLY BRANDING** (or press `F5`). Wait until the status reads **Completed**.
7. Look over the results. Select **PREVIEW** on a result to see it full size.
8. Select **EXPORT** › **Export as ZIP Archive (.zip)**, choose where to save, and select **Save**.

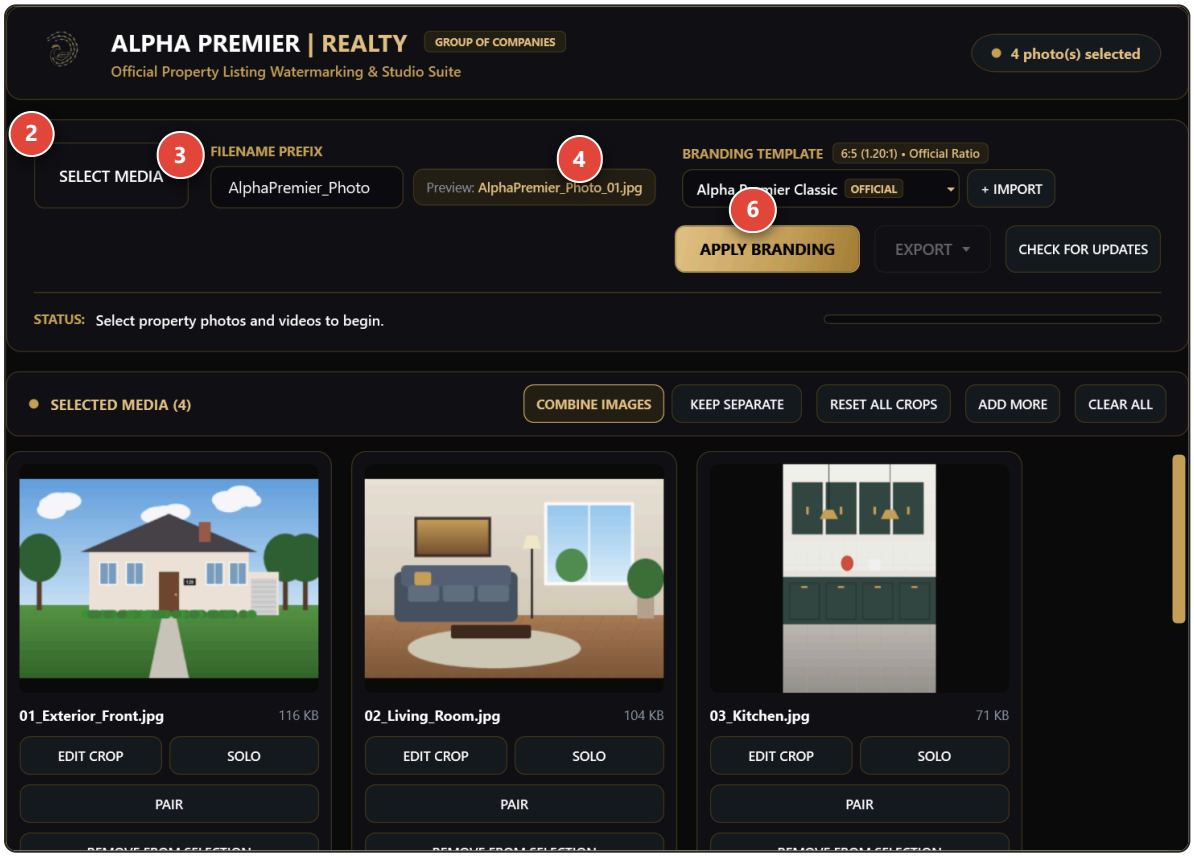



**Figure 3-1.** Photos are staged and ready. The numbers match the quick-start steps above.

> **TIP**
>
> By default, portrait (tall) photos are combined in pairs. Four photos with two portraits give three results: two single photos and one side-by-side pair. See Chapter 6 to change this.

CHAPTER 4

# The main window

The main window has three areas: the header at the top, the control panel in the middle, and the workspace below. The workspace shows a welcome screen, your staged media, or your branded results, depending on where you are in the session.

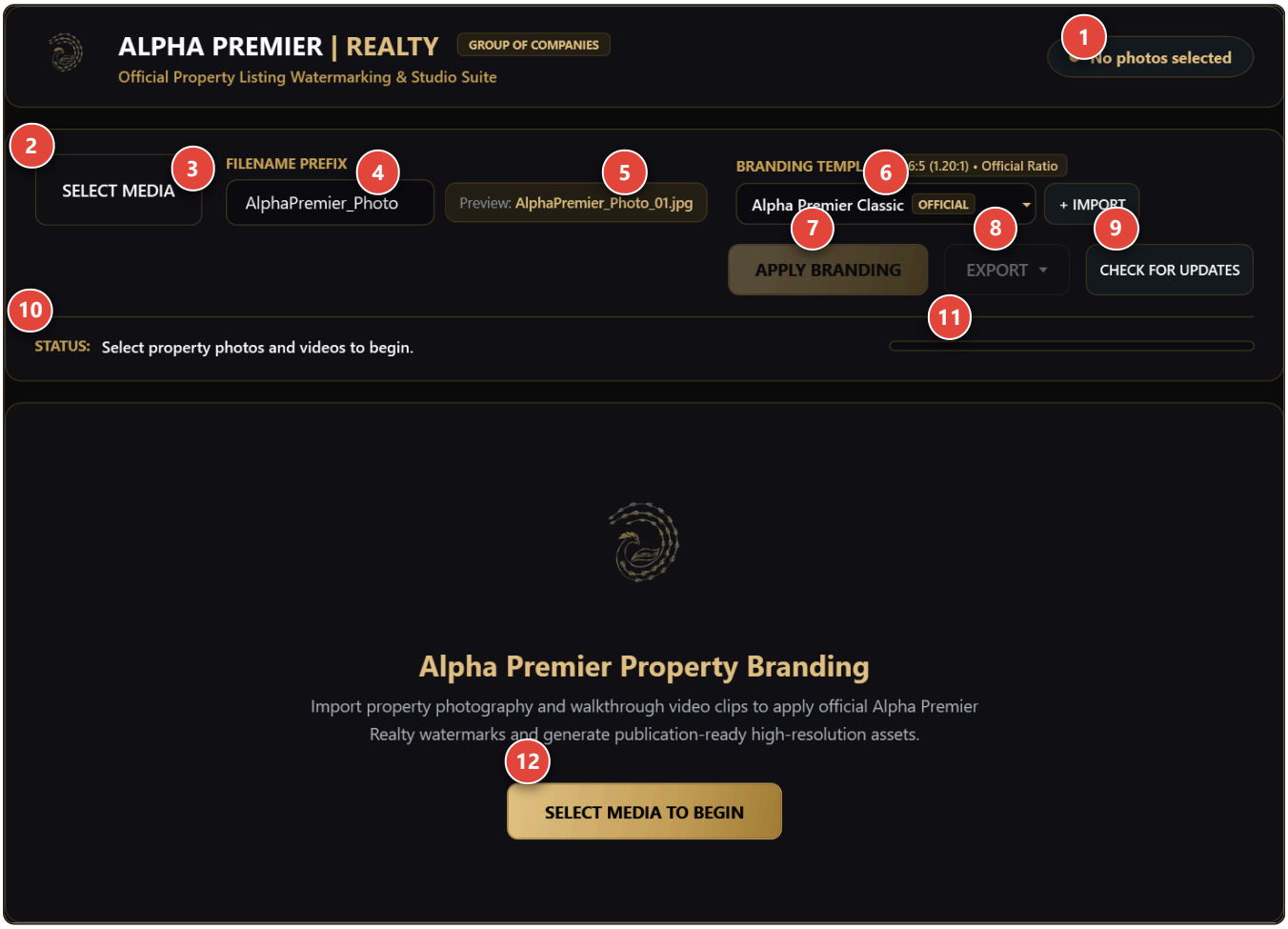



**Figure 4-1.** The main window when you first open the app.

| # | Item | What it does |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Selection counter | Shows how many photos and videos are in the current batch. |
| 2 | **SELECT MEDIA** | Opens a file window so you can choose photos and videos. Starts a new batch. |
| 3 | **FILENAME PREFIX** | The start of every output file name. See Chapter 8. |
| 4 | Preview | Shows what the first output file will be called. |
| 5 | **BRANDING TEMPLATE** | Selects which frame is applied. The badge above it shows the frame's shape. |
| 6 | **+ IMPORT** / **DELETE** | Adds a new template. **DELETE** appears only when a custom template is selected. |
| 7 | **APPLY BRANDING** | Processes every staged item. Available once media is selected. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 8 | **EXPORT** | Saves all results as a ZIP file or as separate files. Available after branding. |
| 9 | **CHECK FOR UPDATES** | Checks for a newer version of the app. See Chapter 13. |
| 10 | **STATUS** | Describes what the app is doing or what just happened. Read this first if something seems wrong. |
| 11 | Progress bar | Fills up while files are loaded, branded, or exported. |
| 12 | Welcome area | Select **SELECT MEDIA TO BEGIN**, or drop files here. |

> **NOTE**
>
> Buttons appear faded when they cannot be used yet. For example, **EXPORT** stays faded until you have branded results, and most buttons are paused while the progress bar is running.

CHAPTER 5

# Adding and managing media

## Supported file types

| Type | File extensions | Output |
|---|---|---|
| Photos | `.jpg` `.jpeg` `.jfif` `.png` `.bmp` `.webp` `.heic` `.heif` | JPG, 1200 × 1000 pixels |
| Videos | `.mp4` `.mov` `.wmv` `.avi` `.m4v` `.mkv` `.webm` | MP4, 1200 × 1000 pixels |

Files of other types are ignored. HEIC and HEIF photos (common on iPhones) are converted automatically.

## Add media

Use any of these methods:

- Select **SELECT MEDIA** or press `Ctrl` + `O`. Hold `Ctrl` to choose several files. This starts a new selection; if your staged photos have crops, pixelate marks, pairs, or SOLO settings, the app asks before replacing them.
- Drag files from File Explorer and drop them on the window. A message reads **DROP VIDEOS & PHOTOS HERE TO IMPORT**. Dropping onto photos you have already staged **adds** the new files; it does not replace them.
- Select **ADD MORE** to add files to the photos you already have. Files that are already staged are not added twice.

## The staged media area

After you add files, each one appears as a card. The bar above the cards contains actions for the whole batch.

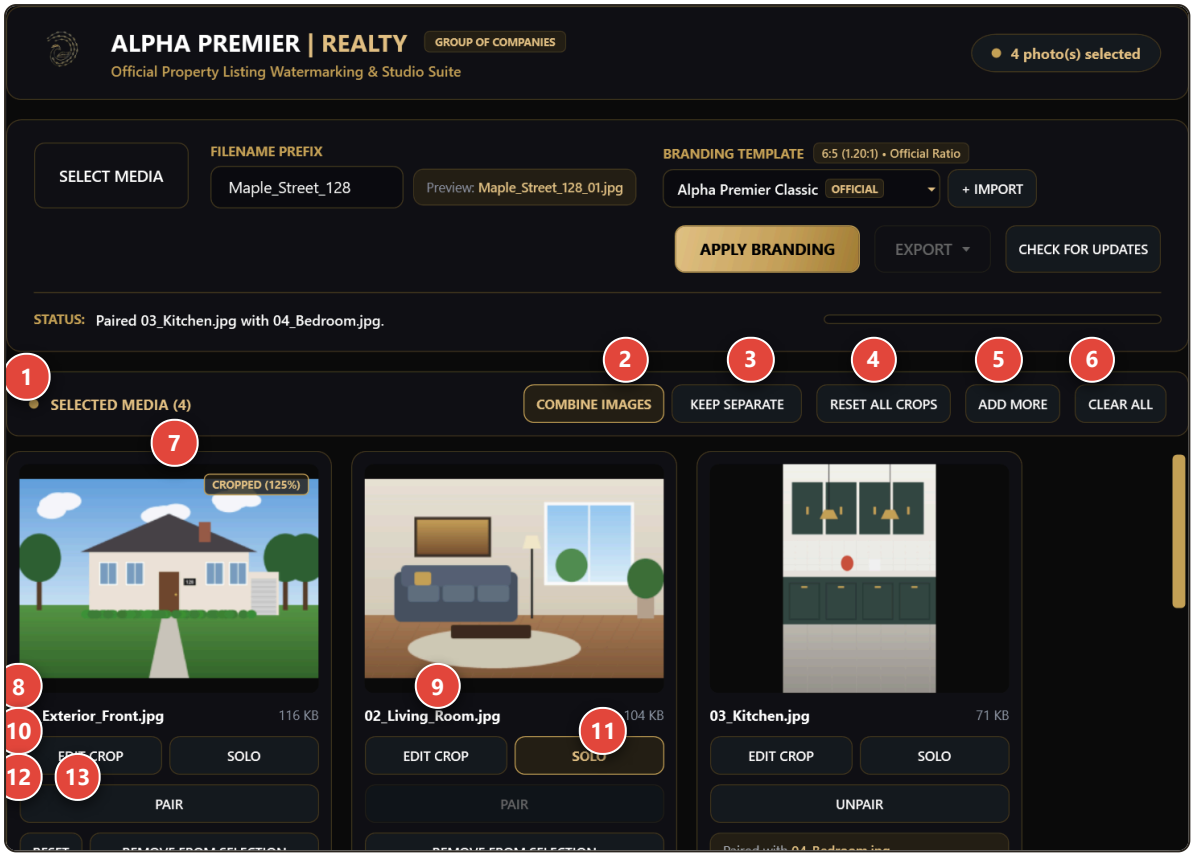



**Figure 5-1.** Staged media. In this example the first photo has a custom crop, the living room photo is set to SOLO (gold), and the kitchen photo is manually paired with the bedroom photo.

| # | Item | What it does |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | **SELECTED MEDIA** | Number of staged items. |
| 2 | **COMBINE IMAGES** | Pairs portrait photos automatically (default). The active layout is shown in gold. Chapter 6. |
| 3 | **KEEP SEPARATE** | Brands every photo on its own. Chapter 6. |
| 4 | **RESET ALL CROPS** | Resets pan, zoom, and rotation on every staged photo. Pixelate marks are kept. |
| 5 | **ADD MORE** | Adds files to the current selection. |
| 6 | **CLEAR ALL** | Removes every staged photo and video. If any have crops, pixelate marks, pairs, or SOLO settings, the app asks first because those edits are lost. Your original files are not deleted. |
| 7 | Crop badge | Shows that the photo has a custom crop and its zoom level, for example **CROPPED (125%)**. Videos show a ▶ **VIDEO** badge with their length instead. |
| 8 | **EDIT CROP** | Opens the Crop & Alignment Editor for this photo. Chapter 7. |
| 9 | **SOLO** | Keeps this photo as its own branded image instead of pairing it. Gold means SOLO is on; select again to turn it off. |
| 10 | **PAIR** | Pairs this photo with the next available photo. Faded while SOLO is on. |

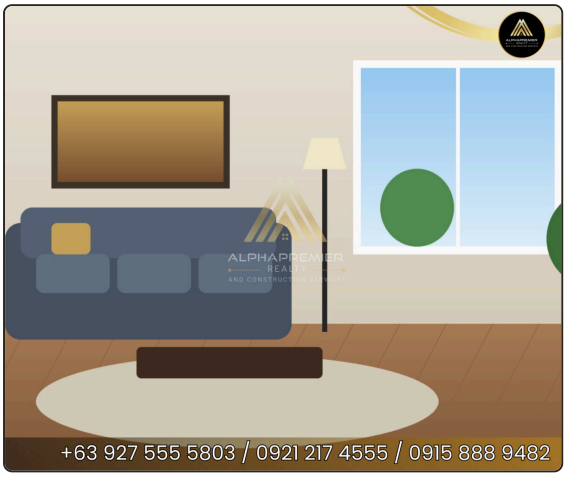
| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 11 | **UNPAIR** and **Paired with** | Replaces **PAIR** on paired photos. The line below names the partner photo. **UNPAIR** returns both photos to automatic layout. |
| 12 | **RESET** | Appears on cropped photos. Resets pan, zoom, and rotation. Pixelate marks are kept. |
| 13 | **REMOVE FROM SELECTION** | Takes this item out of the selection. The original file is not deleted. |

> **NOTE**
> Videos cannot be cropped, paired, or set to SOLO. Their cards show only **REMOVE FROM SELECTION**.

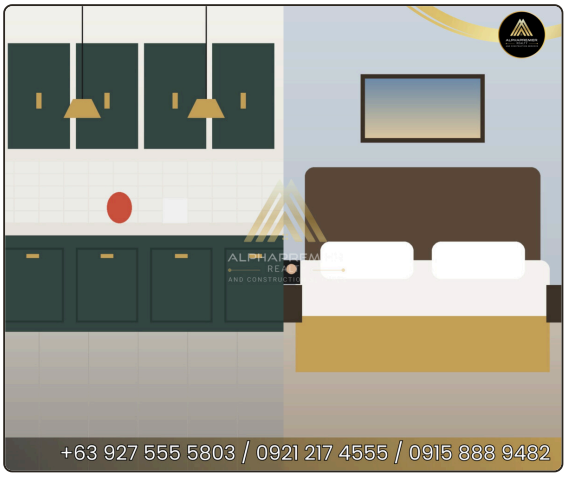
CHAPTER 6

# Photo layouts and pairing

The branding frame is wider than it is tall (6:5). Landscape photos fill it well. A single portrait photo would leave large empty sides, so Branding Studio can place two portrait photos side by side instead.




**Single photo.** One landscape photo fills the frame.




**Combined pair.** Two portrait photos share the frame, 600 × 1000 pixels each.

## Choose a layout for the whole batch

| Button | Result | Best for |
|---|---|---|
| **COMBINE IMAGES** (default) | Portrait photos are paired in the order you added them. Landscape photos stay single. | Mixed batches with tall room shots |
| **KEEP SEPARATE** | Every photo is branded on its own, including portraits. Manual pairs and SOLO settings are ignored. | When every photo must appear alone |

The active layout button is shown in gold.

### How automatic pairing decides

1. Photos you paired by hand are always kept together.
2. The remaining portrait photos are paired in order: first with second, third with fourth, and so on.
3. If one portrait is left over, it is paired with the last landscape photo in the batch.
4. If there is no landscape photo to use, the leftover portrait is placed on both halves of the frame.
5. Results stay in the same order as your original files.

## Set a single photo to SOLO

To keep one photo out of pairing while other photos still combine, select **SOLO** on its card. The button turns gold. Select it again to turn SOLO off.

## Pair two specific photos

If automatic pairing puts the wrong photos together, pair them yourself. Use either method:

- **Drag and drop:** drag one photo card onto another photo card. A highlighted border shows where it will drop.
- **PAIR button:** select **PAIR** on a card. It is paired with the next photo in the list that is not SOLO, not a video, and not already paired.

Paired cards show **UNPAIR** and a **Paired with** line naming the partner. Select **UNPAIR** to remove the pair. Manual pairs are kept when you apply branding and when you rebrand a result.

> **TIP**
> In a pair, the photo that comes first in the staged list appears on the left half of the frame.

> **NOTE**
> SOLO photos and videos cannot be paired, so **PAIR** is faded on them. Turn **SOLO** off first.

CHAPTER 7

# The Crop & Alignment Editor

The editor lets you choose exactly which part of a photo shows inside the frame. The branding overlay is shown on top, so what you see is what will be exported.

To open it, select **EDIT CROP** on a staged photo, on a branded result, or in the Preview window.

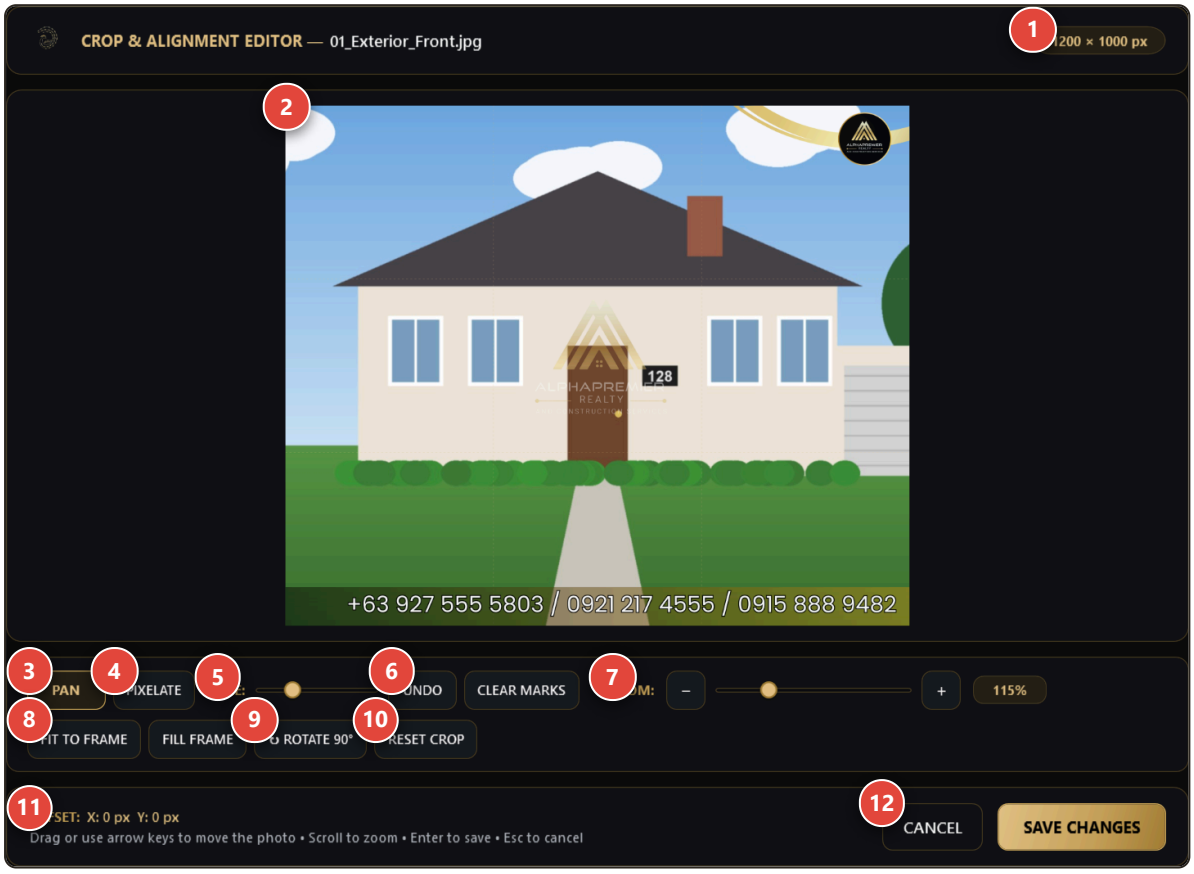



**Figure 7-1.** The Crop & Alignment Editor with a photo zoomed to 115%. The header names the photo being edited.

| # | Control | What it does |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Output size | The final size of this image: 1200 × 1000 px, or 600 × 1000 px for each half of a pair. |
| 2 | Canvas | Drag the photo to move it, or click it and use the arrow keys. Scroll the mouse wheel to zoom. Faint guide lines divide the frame into thirds. |
| 3 | **PAN** | Normal mode (gold when active). Dragging moves the photo. |
| 4 | **PIXELATE** | Brush mode for hiding details. See the next section. |
| 5 | **SIZE** | Brush size for PIXELATE. A bigger brush also makes bigger squares. |
| 6 | **UNDO** / **CLEAR MARKS** | Remove the last mark, or all marks on this photo. |
| 7 | **ZOOM** | **–** and **+** change zoom by 10%; the slider covers 20% to 400%. The box shows the current level. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 8 | **FIT TO FRAME** / **FILL FRAME** | Fit shows the whole photo with no cropping. Fill covers the whole frame and crops the edges evenly. |
| 9 | **ROTATE 90°** | Turns the photo a quarter turn clockwise. Use it for sideways photos. |
| 10 | **RESET CROP** | Returns pan, zoom, and rotation to the default. Pixelate marks are kept. |
| 11 | **OFFSET** | How far the photo has been moved, in pixels, with a hint for the current mode. |
| 12 | **CANCEL** / **SAVE CHANGES** | Cancel (`Esc`) closes without changes. Save (`Enter`) keeps your changes. |

## Frame a photo

1. Select **EDIT CROP** on the photo.
2. If the photo is sideways, select **ROTATE 90°** until it is upright.
3. Select **FILL FRAME** for a clean, edge-to-edge image, or **FIT TO FRAME** to keep the whole photo.
4. Scroll or use the zoom slider to adjust the size, then drag the photo to position it. For fine moves, click the photo and press the arrow keys (hold `Shift` for bigger steps).
5. Keep important parts away from the logo and the contact-number strip at the bottom.
6. Select **SAVE CHANGES**. The card now shows a **CROPPED** badge.

## Edit a combined pair

When you edit a combined result, the editor shows **LEFT PHOTO** and **RIGHT PHOTO** at the top. Select one to adjust it. Each half has its own zoom, position, rotation, and pixelate marks.

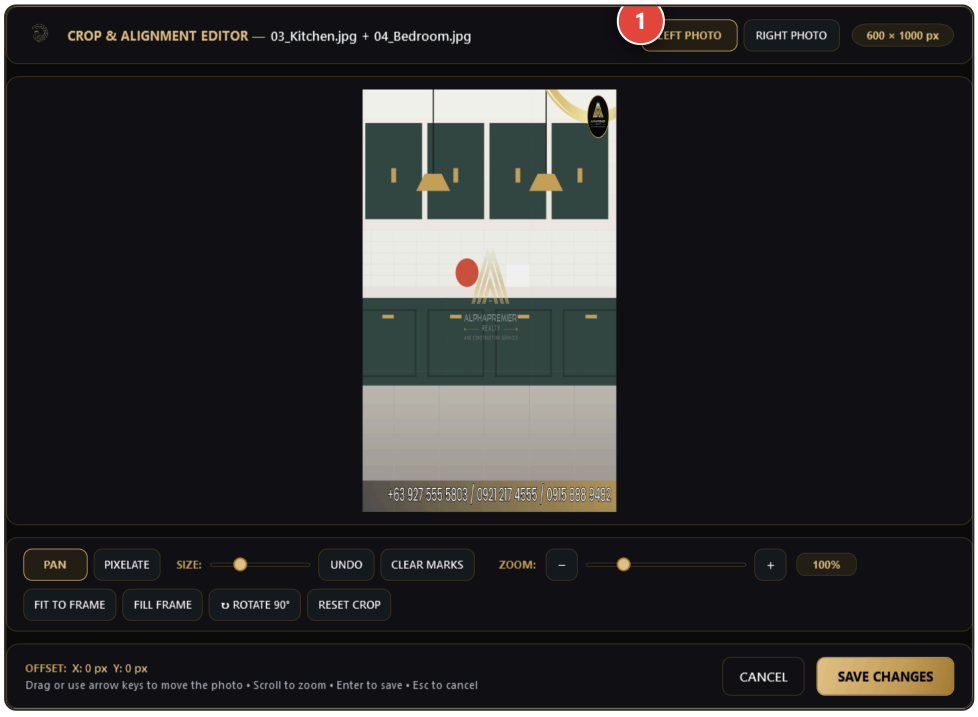



**Figure 7-2.** Editing one half of a pair. 1 switches between the left and right photo.

## Hiding details with PIXELATE

Use PIXELATE to hide things that should not appear in a public listing, such as the owner's phone number on a tarp or sign, house numbers, car plates, faces in family photos, mail, or documents. It turns the area under the brush into large squares. The marks are permanent in the exported image.

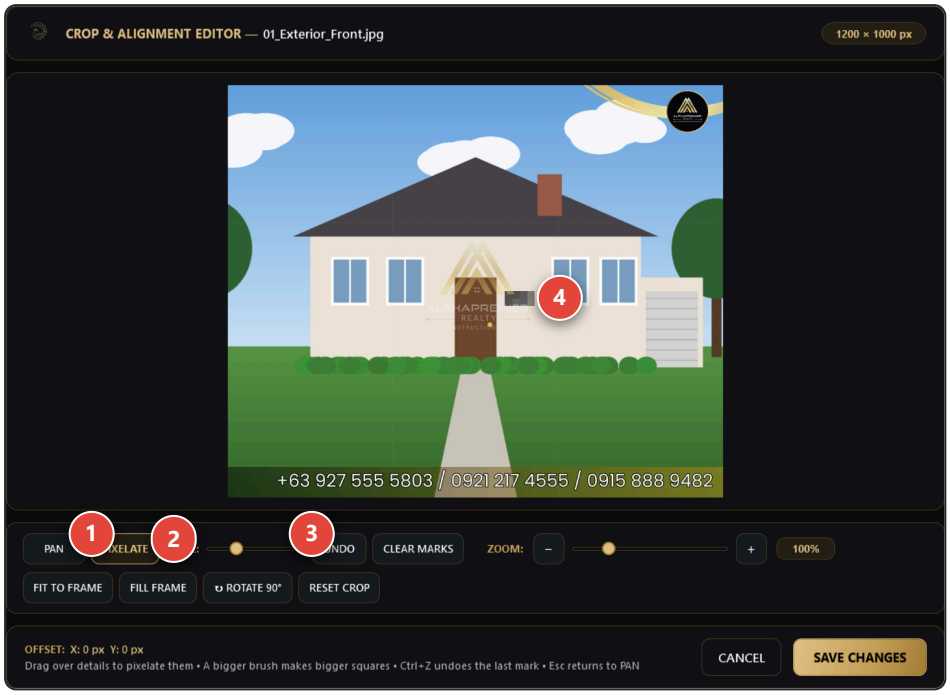



**Figure 7-3.** PIXELATE mode is on 1, the brush size is set with 2, and the house number has been pixelated 4. 3 undoes or clears marks.

1. In the editor, select **PIXELATE**. The button turns gold.
2. Drag the **SIZE** slider until the brush is about as tall as the text to hide. A bigger brush also makes bigger squares.
3. Click and drag over the area to hide. The preview shows it as it will be exported.
4. To remove the last stroke, select **UNDO** or press `Ctrl` + `Z`. To remove all marks on this photo, select **CLEAR MARKS**; **UNDO** brings them back if you change your mind.
5. Select **PAN** (or press `Esc`) to go back to moving the photo.
6. Select **SAVE CHANGES**.

> **NOTE**
>
> Pixelate marks stay attached to the photo. They move, zoom, and rotate with it, and they are kept when you rebrand a result or reset its crop. In a pair, marks belong to the half that was selected when you drew them.

> **CAUTION**
>
> Only **UNDO** and **CLEAR MARKS** remove pixelate marks; **RESET** and **RESET ALL CROPS** keep them. Removing a photo from the selection, or **CLEAR ALL**, discards its marks. Before you export, check that text under each mark can no longer be read; if it can, go over it again with a bigger brush.

**TIP**

In PIXELATE mode, the first press of `Esc` returns to PAN mode. A second press of `Esc` closes the editor without saving.

CHAPTER 8

# File names and branding templates

## Filename prefix

Every output file is named with the prefix, an underscore, and a number. The default prefix is `AlphaPremier_Photo`.

| Prefix you type | Files created |
|---|---|
| `Maple_Street_128` | `Maple_Street_128_01.jpg`, `Maple_Street_128_02.jpg`, `Maple_Street_128_03.mp4` … |
| (left empty) | `AlphaPremier_Photo_01.jpg`, `AlphaPremier_Photo_02.jpg` … |

- Numbers have two digits (01, 02 …). Batches of 100 or more items use three digits (001, 002 …).
- Characters that Windows does not allow in file names ( `/ \ : * ? " < > |` ) are removed automatically.
- Photos are saved as `.jpg` and videos as `.mp4`.
- The ZIP export is named `<prefix>_Export.zip` by default.

> **TIP**
> Use the property address or listing ID as the prefix. Files from different listings will then never be mixed up.

## Branding templates

A template is the frame image placed over each photo. **Alpha Premier Classic** is built in and marked **OFFICIAL**. It cannot be deleted.

### Import a template

1. Select **+ IMPORT** next to **BRANDING TEMPLATE**.
2. Choose a PNG, JPG, JFIF, or WEBP image and select **Open**. Use a PNG with a transparent center so the photo shows through.
3. The app checks the file. If it is valid, the template is saved and selected. If not, a message explains the problem.

The badge beside the label shows the template's shape, for example **6:5 (1.20:1) · Official Ratio**. The shape of the template is always kept; it is never stretched.

### Switch or delete a template

- Choose a template from the **BRANDING TEMPLATE** list. It is used the next time you apply branding or edit a crop.
- To delete a custom template, select it, select **DELETE**, then confirm with **Yes**.

> **NOTE**
> Imported templates are stored on your PC in `%LOCALAPPDATA%\Alpha Premier Realty\Branding Studio\Templates` and are available every time you open the app.

CHAPTER 9

# Applying branding

1. Check the staged items, layout, prefix, and template.
2. Select **APPLY BRANDING**, or press `Ctrl` + `B` or `F5`.
3. Watch the **STATUS** line and progress bar. Videos take longer than photos.
4. When the status reads **Completed**, the workspace switches to **BRANDED ASSETS**.

## What happens to each item

| Item | Result |
|---|---|
| Landscape photo | Cropped to fill the 1200 × 1000 frame (or framed as you set in the editor), then branded. |
| Portrait pair | Each photo fills one 600 × 1000 half, then the frame is added. |
| SOLO photo | Branded on its own in the full frame. |
| Video | The whole video is fitted and centered in a 1200 × 1000 MP4, and the frame is shown for the full length. Videos are not cropped. |

> **NOTE**
> If one file cannot be processed (for example, it is damaged), the status names that file and the rest of the batch continues.

> **CAUTION**
> Selecting **APPLY BRANDING** again starts a new session and replaces the current results. The app always asks you first, so you can export them (Chapter 12).

CHAPTER 10

# Reviewing and fixing results

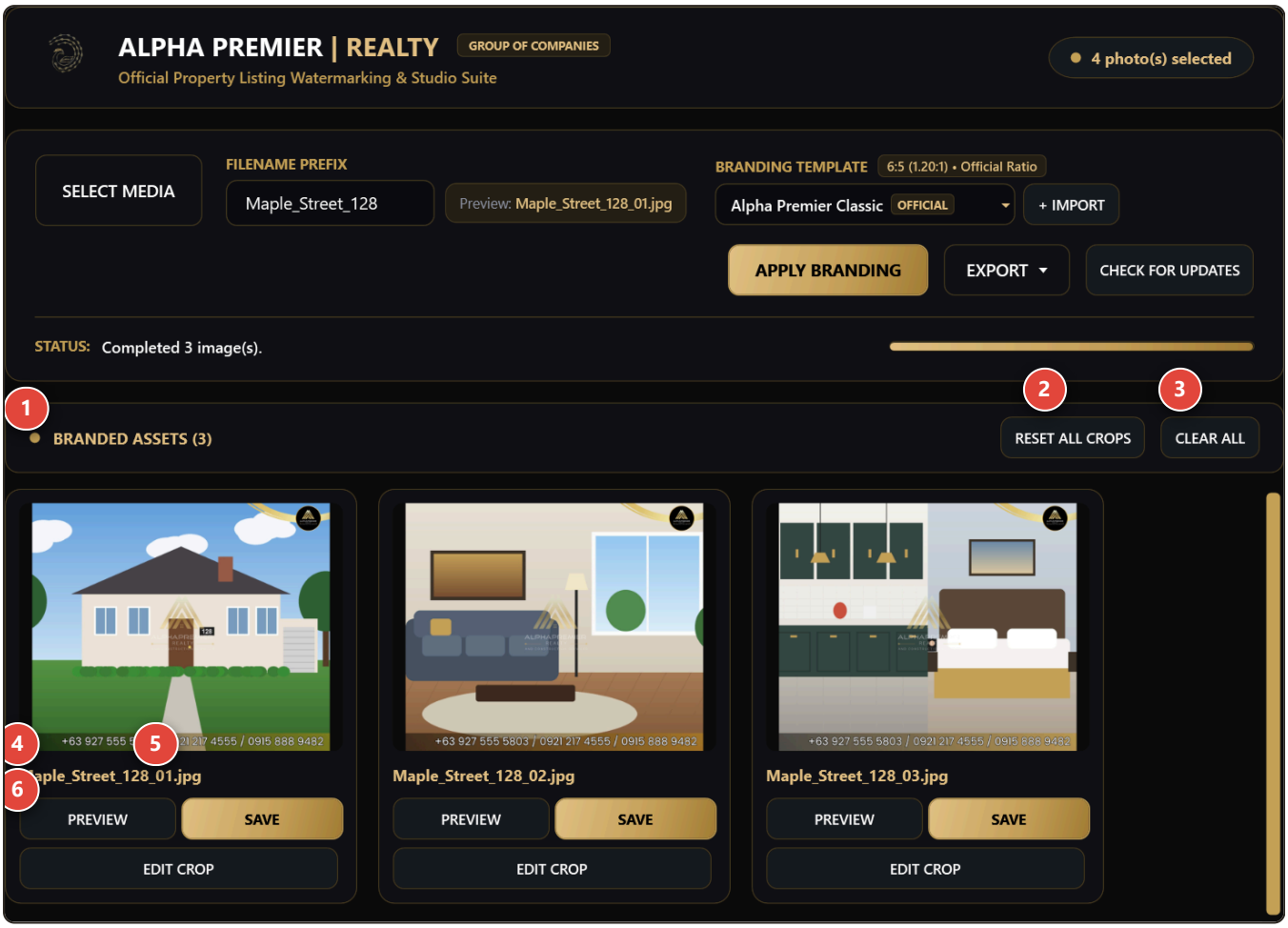



**Figure 10-1.** Branded results. Four photos produced three results, because the two portrait photos were combined.

| # | Item | What it does |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | **BRANDED ASSETS** | Number of finished items. |
| 2 | **RESET ALL CROPS** | Rebrands every result with default pan, zoom, and rotation. Pixelate marks are kept. |
| 3 | **CLEAR ALL** | Removes every branded result and the selection, and returns to the start screen. The app first offers to save them as a ZIP file (Chapter 12). |
| 4 | **PREVIEW** | Opens the result full size. |
| 5 | **SAVE** | Saves this one result to a location you choose. |
| 6 | **EDIT CROP** | Opens the editor and rebrands this result when you save. A **RESET** button appears on results with a custom crop. |

> **NOTE: SESSION NOTICE**
>
> Right after branding, no notice appears beside **APPLY BRANDING**. A notice appears there only when something changes. After you edit a result, it reads **Unsaved edits in current session.** If the selected media no longer matches the branded results, it reads, for example, **5 new photo(s) selected — applying branding will start a new session.**

## Preview window

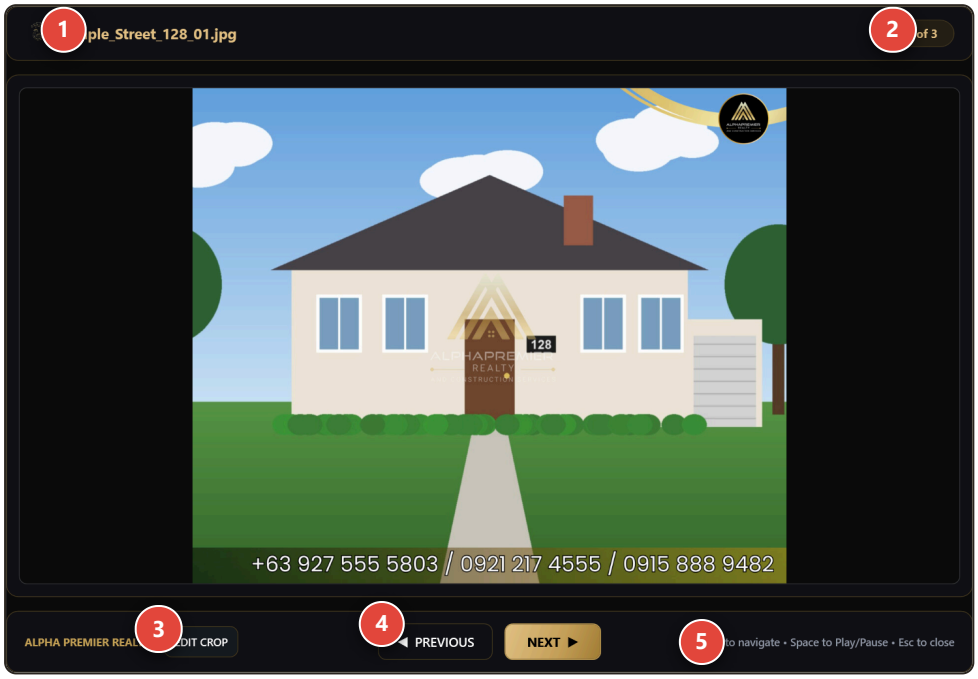



**Figure 10-2.** The Preview window: 1 file name, 2 position in the batch, 3 edit this result, 4 previous and next, 5 keyboard hints.

- Press ← and → or select **◀ PREVIOUS** and **NEXT ▶** to move between results.
- For videos, use the play/pause button, the timeline, and the mute button. Press **Space** to play or pause.
- Press **Esc** to close the Preview window.

## Fix a result without starting over

1. Select **EDIT CROP** on the result card or in the Preview window.
2. Adjust the framing or add PIXELATE marks, then select **SAVE CHANGES**.
3. Only that result is rebranded. Its name and position in the batch do not change.

CHAPTER 11

# Saving and exporting

Branded results exist only inside the app until you save or export them. Choose the method that suits how you will share the files.

| Method | How | Result |
|---|---|---|
| **Export as ZIP Archive (.zip)** | `EXPORT` › **Export as ZIP Archive (.zip)**, or `Ctrl` + `E` (also `Ctrl` + `S`) | One ZIP file with every result |
| **Export as Individual Files…** | `EXPORT` › **Export as Individual Files…**, or `Ctrl` + `Shift` + `E` | Every result saved into a folder you choose |
| **Save one result** | `SAVE` on a result card | One JPG or MP4 file |

## Export everything as a ZIP file

1. Select `EXPORT`. A menu opens below the button.
2. Select **Export as ZIP Archive (.zip)**.
3. Choose a folder. The file name is filled in as `<prefix>_Export.zip`; you can change it.
4. Select **Save**. The status shows progress and then confirms the export.

## Export as separate files

1. Select `EXPORT` › **Export as Individual Files…**
2. Choose or create a folder and confirm.
3. Each result is saved with its numbered name, for example `Maple_Street_128_01.jpg`.

> **CAUTION**
> Files in the folder with the same names are replaced without asking. Use an empty folder for each listing.

> **TIP**
> ZIP files are easiest to email or upload in one step. Separate files are easiest to drag into a listing website.

CHAPTER 12

# Sessions and unsaved work

A **session** is one batch of branded results. Branding Studio protects your results so you do not lose them by accident.

The app asks before it replaces or closes a session that has results, when you:

- apply branding again while you still have results,
- load a new batch of media,
- select **CLEAR ALL** in the branded assets view, or
- close the app.

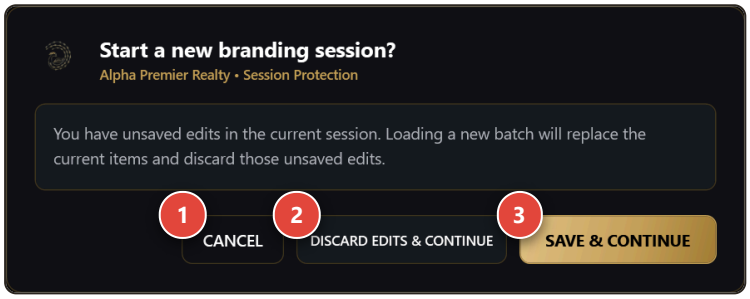



**Figure 12-1.** The session protection message.

| # | Choice | What happens |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | **CANCEL** | Nothing changes. You return to your current session. |
| 2 | **DISCARD EDITS & CONTINUE** | The current results are discarded and the app continues. |
| 3 | **SAVE & CONTINUE** | You save the current results as a ZIP file first, then the app continues. |

> **CAUTION**
> Discarded results cannot be recovered. Your original photos and videos are never changed or deleted, so you can brand them again.

CHAPTER 13

# Software updates

Branding Studio checks for a new version:

- a few seconds after it opens,
- every 8 hours while it is running, and
- when you select **CHECK FOR UPDATES** (on a Mac, choose **Alpha Branding Studio › Check for Updates...** in the menu bar).

On Windows, when a newer version is available, this window appears:

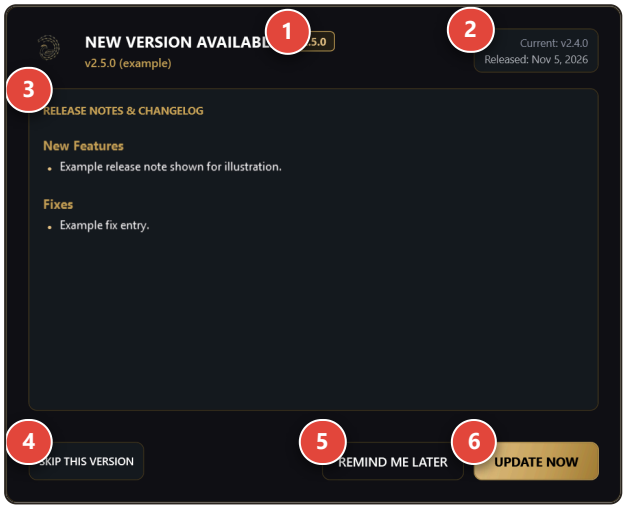



**Figure 13-1.** The update window (example version numbers).

| # | Item | What it does |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | New version | The version that is available. |
| 2 | Current / Released | Your current version and the release date of the new one. |
| 3 | Release notes | What is new or fixed. |
| 4 | **SKIP THIS VERSION** | Stops reminders for this version. You are told again when a newer one comes out. |
| 5 | **REMIND ME LATER** | Closes the window. You are reminded in about 8 hours. |
| 6 | **UPDATE NOW** | Downloads the update, checks its digital signature, and starts the installer. The app closes while the update installs. |

**CAUTION**

Export your results before selecting **UPDATE NOW**. The app closes to install the update.

**NOTE**

If a download fails, the window shows an error and an **OPEN IN BROWSER** button so you can download the installer manually. If your IT team has turned off updates, the check reports that updates are disabled by system policy.

## Updates on a Mac

On a Mac (version 2.8.0 or later), a message shows the new version, your current version, and what is new, with three buttons:

| Button | What it does |
|---|---|
| **Update Now** | Downloads the Mac installer, checks it against the checksum published with the release, opens it, and quits the app. Follow the installer to finish. |
| **Remind Me Later** | Closes the message. You are reminded in about 8 hours. |
| **Skip This Version** | Stops reminders for this version. You are told again when a newer one comes out. |

> **CAUTION**
>
> Export your results before selecting **Update Now**. If you have results that are not exported, the app asks before it quits.

> **NOTE**
>
> Automatic checks wait until branding in progress has finished. If a check cannot reach GitHub, **Check for Updates...** shows why; automatic checks stay silent. If a downloaded installer does not match its published checksum, it is deleted and nothing is installed.

CHAPTER 14

# Keyboard and mouse reference

## Main window

| Shortcut | Action |
|---|---|
| `Ctrl` + `O` | Select media |
| `Ctrl` + `B` or `F5` | Apply branding |
| `Ctrl` + `E` or `Ctrl` + `S` | Export as ZIP archive |
| `Ctrl` + `Shift` + `E` | Export as individual files |
| Drag files onto the window | Add media |
| Drag a photo card onto another card | Pair the two photos |

## Crop & Alignment Editor

| Shortcut | Action |
|---|---|
| Mouse wheel | Zoom in or out |
| Click and drag (PAN mode) | Move the photo |
| Click and drag (PIXELATE mode) | Pixelate the area under the brush |
| Arrow keys (photo selected) | Move the photo; hold `Shift` for bigger steps |
| `Ctrl` + `Z` | Undo the last mark, or undo CLEAR MARKS |
| `Esc` | Leave PIXELATE mode; press again to cancel and close |
| `Enter` | Save changes |

## Preview window

| Shortcut | Action |
|---|---|
| `←` / `→` | Previous or next result |
| `Space` | Play or pause a video |
| `Esc` | Close the preview |

> **TIP**
> Hover over any button to see a short description of what it does.

CHAPTER 15

# Troubleshooting and FAQ

| Problem | What to do |
|---|---|
| A file I chose does not appear. | Check that its type is in the supported list (Chapter 5). Files of other types are ignored. Files already in the batch are not added twice. |
| **APPLY BRANDING** or **EXPORT** is faded. | Apply needs at least one staged item. Export needs branded results. Both wait while the progress bar is running. |
| The wrong photos were combined. | Drag one photo onto the one it belongs with, or use **UNPAIR** and **PAIR**. To stop combining, select **KEEP SEPARATE** or set photos to **SOLO**. |
| Important parts are cut off. | Open **EDIT CROP** and select **FIT TO FRAME**, or zoom out and move the photo. |
| A photo is sideways. | Open **EDIT CROP** and select **ROTATE 90°**. |
| A status message names a file that was skipped. | That file could not be read and may be damaged. Open it in the Windows Photos app; if it does not open there, get a new copy of the file. |
| A HEIC photo shows an error. | The file may be damaged. Export it from your phone again as JPG or HEIC and retry. |
| A video takes a long time. | This is normal for long or high-resolution clips. Wait for the progress bar to finish. |
| “Invalid Template” appears when importing. | Use a PNG, JPG, JFIF, or WEBP image that opens normally. PNG with a transparent center is recommended. |
| The update check says the rate limit was exceeded. | Too many checks were made from your network. Try again later. |
| The update check says updates are disabled. | Your IT team has turned off updates on this PC. Ask them for the latest version. |
| A Mac never offers updates. | Mac versions before 2.8.0 have no update check. Install the latest Mac installer once (Chapter 2); later versions are offered automatically. |
| Buttons look cramped on a laptop. | Maximize the window. At high display scaling, button rows wrap and the media area scrolls. |

## Frequently asked questions

### Are my original photos changed?

No. Branding Studio only reads your originals. Branded copies are saved only where you export them.

### Does the app need the internet?

Only to check for and download updates. Branding, cropping, and exporting work offline.

### Can I close the app and continue later?

No. Results are not kept after the app closes. Export your results before closing; the app reminds you if you forget.

### Why did four photos give me three results?

Two portrait photos were combined into one frame. Select **KEEP SEPARATE** if you want one result per photo.

### Can I remove pixelate marks after exporting?

Not from the exported file. While the session is still open, select **EDIT CROP** on the result, select **CLEAR MARKS**, save, and export again.

### Where do I get help?

Contact your office IT administrator. Releases and release notes are listed at `github.com/Deign86/Alpha_Branding/releases`.

CHAPTER 16

# Specifications and glossary

## Output specifications

| Item | Value |
|---|---|
| Photo output | JPG, 1200 × 1000 pixels (6:5) |
| Each half of a pair | 600 × 1000 pixels |
| Video output | MP4, 1200 × 1000 pixels, original video fitted and centered |
| Zoom range in the editor | 20% to 400% |
| Rotation | 90° steps, clockwise |
| File numbering | 01–99; 001 and up for batches of 100 or more |
| Default prefix | `AlphaPremier_Photo` |
| Saved templates | `%LOCALAPPDATA%\Alpha Premier Realty\Branding Studio\Templates` |
| Update checks | At start-up, every 8 hours, and on request |

## Glossary

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Branding / frame | The Alpha Premier logo, gold accents, and contact strip placed over each photo. |
| Template | The image file that contains the frame. |
| Staged media | Photos and videos you have selected but not yet branded. |
| Result / branded asset | A finished, branded photo or video. |
| Session | One batch of results, from applying branding until you start again or close the app. |
| Combine / pair | Two portrait photos placed side by side in one frame. |
| SOLO | A photo that is always branded on its own, never paired. |
| Portrait / landscape | A photo that is taller than it is wide / wider than it is tall. |
| Pan | Moving the photo inside the frame. |
| Fit / Fill | Show the whole photo / cover the whole frame. |
| Pixelate marks | PIXELATE brush marks that hide details in a photo. |
| Prefix | The text at the start of every output file name. |